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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, APRIL 29, 2025 • \$4

Civil rights lawyers flee Justice as focus shifts

Director reassigns staff to combat antisemitism and diversity initiatives

BY PERRY STEIN
AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

The new head of the Justice Department's civil rights division is dramatically reshaping the office to propel President Donald Trump's social agenda, prompting the departure of about half of the division's lawyers in recent weeks, according to people familiar with the situation and public statements from top officials.

Since being sworn in this month, civil rights director Harmeet K. Dhillon has redirected her staff to focus on combating antisemitism, the participation of transgender athletes in women's sports and what Trump and his allies have described as anti-Christian bias and the Democrats' "woke ideology."

The division changed mission statements across its sections to focus less on racial discrimination and more on fighting diversity initiatives. And officials reassigned more than a dozen career staffers — including section chiefs overseeing police brutality, disability and voting rights cases — to areas outside their legal expertise.

The changes under Dhillon, a longtime Republican activist, coincide with a second White House offer to federal workers that allows them to resign from their positions and be paid through September. The deadline for that offer was late Monday evening, SEE CIVIL RIGHTS ON A2

Independents: Their approval of Trump is eroding, polls find. **A3**

Agencies turn to polygraph tests in hunt for leakers

Current, former officials describe sense of dread at FBI and Pentagon

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA
AND HANNAH NATANSON

National security agencies across the Trump administration are ramping up investigations into alleged leaks to the news media, in some cases using polygraph tests that current and former officials say are creating a climate of fear and intimidation.

At FBI Director Kash Patel's direction, the bureau in recent weeks has begun administering polygraph tests to identify the source of information leaks, an FBI spokesperson said. The new use of polygraphs at the bureau, which are commonly known as "lie detector" tests, has not been previously reported.

"The seriousness of the specific leaks in question precipitated the polygraphs, as they involved potential damage to security protocols at the bureau," said the spokesperson, who declined to elaborate.

The ramp-up has been bolstered by Attorney General Pam Bondi's new legal guidelines that allow the Justice Department to subpoena reporters' personal communications and broaden the

SEE POLYGRAPH ON A6



JOHN MCDONNELL/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Commanders owner Josh Harris, left, and NFL Commissioner Roger Goodell, right, watch Mayor Muriel E. Bowser sign a helmet.

A deal, and a return to D.C.

Commanders, city agree to build a stadium at RFK site by 2030, but plenty of roadblocks remain

BY MEAGAN FLYNN,
SAM FORTIER
AND NICKI JHABVALA

D.C. and the Washington Commanders have reached a \$3.7 billion deal to transform the dilapidated RFK Stadium site on the banks of the Anacostia River into a new home for the NFL team surrounded by retail, housing and park space — a generational development project likely to shape the legacies of Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) and Commanders owner Josh Harris.

Sprawling across 177 waterfront acres, the massive development anchored by a covered 65,000-seat stadium would be funded primarily by the Commanders, who would put up \$2.7 billion, according to the terms released Monday. The total cost to D.C. taxpayers is expected to top \$1 billion, including stadium infrastructure, parking facilities, recreation improvements and other water and electric infrastructure — a price tag likely to spur heated debate on the D.C. Council and among residents about how public money is used.

\$1 billion+

expected cost to taxpayers

65,000

stadium seats

177 acres

total project size

5,000-6,000

new housing units planned for the site

Candace Buckner: Mayor ties her legacy to D.C.'s sports teams playing in D.C. **D1**

A D.C. Super Bowl? Roofed stadium could put city in mix for the NFL's biggest game. **D1**

Any cost overruns will be covered by the Commanders, Harris said.

The council still must approve the deal, and Bowser is expected to include the public financing components in the 2026 capital budget submission in the coming weeks. The team and city are hoping to move quickly. They plan to begin construction next year and have the new stadium open for the 2030 season. That would require the council to approve the terms of the deal by July, and lawmakers could propose changes.

At a joint news conference Monday, an elated Bowser took the stage alongside Harris and NFL Commissioner Roger Goodell to the riffs of Mambo Sauce's "Welcome to D.C." with a "WELCOME HOME" banner hanging behind them in Commanders burgundy and gold.

"This is a big deal. I've been working on this for the 10 years since I've been mayor, and now we have the right partner at the right time," Bowser said. "We were joined in our goals to advance a deal that we could be

SEE RFK ON A7

Operation Babylift's adoptees look back to Vietnam

BY PETULA DVORAK

They are turning 50 now, the babies laid out on airplane seats, six to a row, held and fed by strangers who took turns caring for them as they took artillery fire and fled the bombs and booms of Saigon.

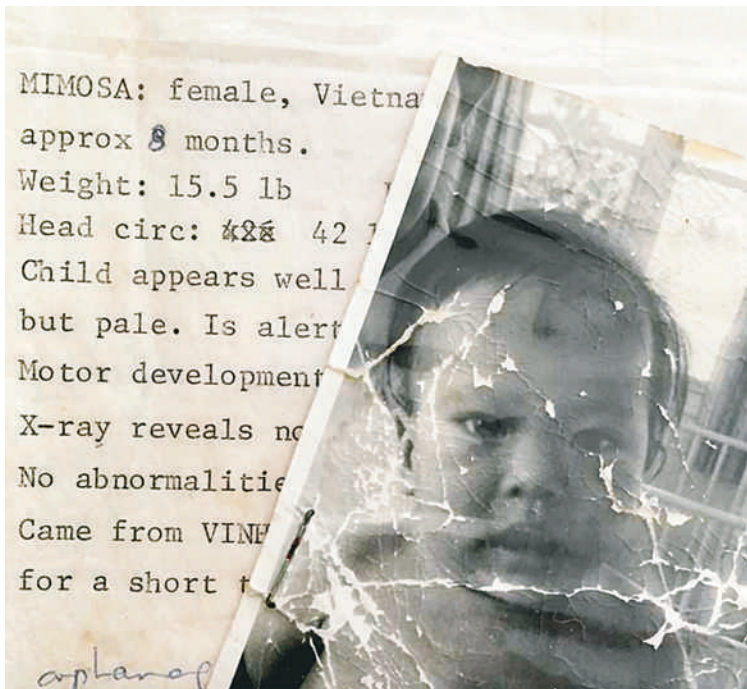
They were part of Operation Babylift, an effort led by the American military to rescue babies from Vietnamese orphanages ahead of the fall of Saigon 50 years ago this month.

"This is the least we can do, and we will do much, much more," President Gerald Ford said on April 3, 1975.

The operation came after 10 grueling years of U.S. involvement in the 20-year-long Vietnam War, a conflict that took millions of Vietnamese lives, more than 58,000 American lives and divided the country. As the North Vietnamese closed in on Saigon in April 1975, American civilians were evacuated en masse.

The first Operation Babylift flight was catastrophic: The C-5A carrying more than 300 people crashed into a rice paddy 27 minutes after takeoff, killing 78 babies and about 50 adults, includ-

As the children flown to America ahead of Saigon's fall enter their 50s, some are seeking to connect with their origins



DEVAKI MURCH

Devaki Murch was one of the children who survived the crash of the first Operation Babylift flight out of Saigon, Vietnam, in 1975.

ing 35 American military personnel.

The babies who survived didn't remember it.

And as children growing up in American homes, often as the only Asian American kids in their Wonder Bread hometowns, forgetting the crash or the airlift or the reason they were adopted was a matter of survival.

"My family was just amazing and wonderful," said Devaki Murch, who was one of the 175 people who survived. "I never felt like I was missing something, or there was never a yearning to learn more."

But with age comes introspection.

"The majority of us are about 50 years old now," Murch said. "And a lot of us have lived enough life to go back and maybe learn a little more and make those connections."

She found these connections in the basement of the Colorado office of the adoption agency that worked in Vietnam, Friends for All Children.

"As I brought box after box up from the basement, it wasn't just adoptee files; there were about 25

SEE BABYLIFT ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Papal conclave The meeting to pick Pope Francis's successor will begin May 7, the Vatican said, as intrigues around the election began to emerge. **A9**

A darn good time A D.C. library hosted an event teaching people to stitch, mend and repair their clothing to fight fast fashion. **B1**

THE NATION
Sen. Brian Schatz (Hawaii) launched his run to be the chamber's No. 2 Democrat. **A5**
Americans are increasingly critical of Elon Musk's government role, a poll finds. **A6**

THE WORLD
A power outage paralyzed Spain and Portugal as officials searched for the cause. **A8**
Russia declared a three-day ceasefire for Victory Day, an annual World War II event. **A13**

THE ECONOMY
Acyn Torabi has helped shape liberal media with fast-cut viral video clips of political mayhem on social media. **A14**

THE REGION
Rep. Gerry Connolly, whose cancer has returned, will resign his committee role and won't seek reelection. **B1**

A man suspected of stealing Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem's purse was charged in federal court. **B1**

Virginia officials expanded their warning about medical facilities in the commonwealth exposed to a child with measles. **B1**

STYLE
Scheels, a maximalist sporting-goods retailer/indoor amusement park, has captured hearts in the middle of the U.S. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE
The catchy song that bored its way into your cranium can be tough to get rid of — but there are ways to de-earworm. **E1**

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